> cold, and I had nothing to cover me but my chogah. I examined the roof of the house during the day, and it appeared to me that by removing a few of the bricks from the chimney I might get out unobserved. At night I did so, and effected my escape.

But not for long. ‘I had got five coss further down the road to Jalalabad when the son of a sirdar who was fighting at Kabul sent some horsemen to take and bring me to him. All the villagers, young and old, male and female, gathered around exclaiming, “a Kafir or Feringhee: kill him, kill him”; but the young chief protected me from violence, and told me to groom his horse.’ Added Moti Ram: ‘This young man was continually looking in the direction of Kabul, through a telescope which he said Sir A Burnes had given his father as a present.’[74]

On 20 November the rebels’ guns were suddenly stilled, and for the next three days there were no attacks on the cantonment. Only on the morning of the 23rd did it become clear that the days of quiet had been to allow the rebels to manufacture ammunition and powder. That morning, before dawn, the Kohistanis under Mir Masjidi massed in huge numbers on the heights above the cantonment, digging breastworks and trenches, and completely cutting off the British from their food supplies in Bibi Mahru. They then began to bombard the cantonment with their artillery. Shelton was soon sent out to try to clear the heights.

‘The sound of artillery fire rolled like thunder,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata. ‘Abdullah Khan Achakzai Ghazi heard the sound of fierce fighting, and hastened to reinforce the jihadis at Bibi Mahru: they trampled the English soldiers under the hooves of their horses, they cut them down with their sharp swords, then captured the English gun, and shouting “Allah hu-akbar! God is great!” they charged the English.’

In order to defend himself against the cavalry, Shelton then formed his infantry into two squares at the summit of the hill, the standard British defence against mounted attack that had been so effective against Napoleon’s lancers at Waterloo. But it proved a disastrous tactic in Afghanistan. The Afghans simply pulled back, allowing the jezail marksmen to come forward and from behind the cover of stones and rocks fire into the densely packed British ranks while keeping well out of range of British muskets. The British were easy targets: a solid mass of scarlet uniforms standing completely still for hours on end silhouetted on a ridge.